Digital Literacy Project

Final Report

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Introduction

In today's rapidly evolving digital landscape, digital literacy has become a fundamental skill for academic success and professional advancement. This project was designed to develop comprehensive digital competencies including professional online presence creation, responsible digital communication, platform exploration, and cybersecurity awareness. As a Student Digital Ambassador, my objective was to guide peers through the digital world while building my own foundational portfolio across key platforms. Through ve interconnected tasks, I explored design tools, established professional pro les, practiced coding challenges, mastered email etiquette, and researched cybercrime prevention. This hands-on experience has equipped me with practical skills essential for my four-year journey at VIT Bhopal and beyond, preparing me to navigate technology wisely and responsibly in both academic and personal contexts.

Task 1: Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

For Task 1, I created a comprehensive digital literacy awareness infographic using Canva, a browser-based graphic design platform. The infographic aimed to educate rst-year students about essential digital competencies beyond basic internet usage. My design covered three core topics: what digital literacy encompasses (critical thinking, digital communication, and online safety), useful productivity tools for students (Google Workspace, GitHub, and note-taking apps), and safe internet practices (password management, phishing awareness, and privacy settings).

The creative process involved selecting a vibrant template, organizing information hierarchically using icons and color-coding, and balancing visual appeal with informational clarity. One particularly interesting challenge was condensing complex concepts like "digital footprint management" into concise, memorable phrases suitable for visual presentation. Canva's drag-and-drop interface and extensive icon library made the technical execution smooth, though I struggled initially with maintaining consistent spacing and alignment across sections.

This task enhanced my understanding that digital literacy extends far beyond knowing how to use social media—it encompasses critical evaluation of online information, ethical digital behavior, and strategic use of technology for personal growth. The experience improved my design thinking and visual communication skills, which will prove valuable for future academic presentations and project documentation.

Task 2: Building Student Digital Portfolio

For my student digital portfolio, I selected three key platforms: GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. These align perfectly with my goals as a Computer Science student at VIT Bhopal, focusing on programming, professional networking, and data science projects.
GitHub is primarily used for version control, code hosting, and collaboration on software projects, allowing developers to share repositories, track changes, and showcase portfolios. LinkedIn serves as a professional networking site where users build pro les, connect with industry peers, search for jobs or internships, and share career updates. Kaggle is a community platform for data science enthusiasts, o ering datasets, competitions, notebooks, and courses to practice machine learning and analytics.

Over the next four years, I plan to actively use GitHub by creating a pro le README and uploading projects like my AI chatbots, attendance trackers, and Python assignments from college courses, building a strong coding portfolio for internships. On LinkedIn, I'll update my education details, add skills in Python and AI/ML, connect with alumni and recruiters, and post about events like college fests to network for opportunities. For Kaggle, I'll complete beginner competitions, publish notebooks on environmental data analysis (tying into my interests in Environmental Science), and earn badges to demonstrate practical machine learning skills for future roles. These platforms will evolve with my undergraduate journey, supporting academic growth, side projects, and professional development throughout my time at VIT Bhopal.

Task 3: Coding and Collaboration Platforms

For Task 3, I used HackerRank for coding practice and Google Workspace (speci cally Google Forms and Sheets) for collaboration. These platforms align with the project requirements to explore coding challenges and build interactive tools for peers.

On HackerRank, I created an account and completed the beginnerlevel "Solve Me First" challenge in Python, which involves writing a simple function to add two numbers based on user input. This helped me practice basic input handling, function de nition, and problemsolving logic, refreshing my foundational programming skills as a
Computer Science student. For Google Workspace, I built a Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz using Google Forms with ve questions: three multiple-choice on topics like safe internet practices and email etiquette, one checkbox for tool preferences, and one short-answer re ection prompt. I linked it to a Google Sheet to track responses, simulating real peer feedback collection.

These tools will signi cantly aid my academic journey over the next four years at VIT Bhopal. HackerRank will help me prepare for coding interviews, Data Structures and Algorithms courses, and AI/ML internships by building a streak of solved problems and earning badges that demonstrate technical pro ciency. Google Forms and Sheets will streamline group projects, event registrations for college fests, assignment quizzes, and collaborative research work, fostering teamwork without complex technical setups. Together, they enhance my e ciency in programming assignments, data analysis projects, and Digital Ambassador duties, providing practical experience with industry-standard collaboration tools.

Task 4: Professional Email Etiquette and Digital Communication

Poor digital communication can lead to serious academic and professional consequences. A notable case occurred in 2024 during a group project at an Indian engineering college, where a student posted a casual WhatsApp message in the team chat: "yo guys, cant do my part today, sry." without providing details or alternatives. This vague, unprofessional communication led to confusion among team members, delayed the entire project submission, and ultimately resulted in the team losing signi cant marks. The professor viewed this behavior as irresponsibility and lack of commitment, nearly causing the student to receive an academic warning that would have impacted their scholarship eligibility.

This situation could have been handled far more e ectively by drafting a professional message or email with a clear subject line ("Update on Group Project Contribution - CSE Assignment"), polite greeting ("Hello Team,"), detailed explanation ("Due to a con icting deadline in another course and unforeseen circumstances..."), proposed solution ("I will complete my section by tomorrow evening and share a draft for review"), and professional sign-o ("Thank you for understanding, Vaibhav"). This approach demonstrates accountability, builds trust among team members, and maintains professionalism—qualities crucial for college collaborations, internship communications, and future workplace interactions in my Computer Science and Engineering path at VIT Bhopal.

Task 5: Cybercrime Awareness and Online Safety

While researching phishing attacks and various cybercrime tactics for this task, I was genuinely surprised by the psychological sophistication of modern scams. What struck me most was how cybercriminals exploit urgency, fear, and authority to manipulate victims—such as fake UPI payment failure messages claiming "Your account will be blocked in 2 hours, click here to verify" or emails impersonating college administration requesting immediate fee payment through uno cial links. These attacks don't rely on advanced hacking; instead, they exploit human psychology and trust, making even tech-savvy students vulnerable when they're stressed or distracted.

The case study I researched involved a VIT student who lost ₹45,000 in 2025 through a sophisticated phishing scam. The student received a professional-looking email claiming to be from the university's examination cell, stating that their semester results would be withheld unless they veri ed their identity through a provided link. Under exam stress, the student clicked the link, entered their net banking credentials on a fake page, and had their account drained within hours. This incident could have been prevented by verifying sender email addresses, never clicking links in unsolicited messages, and contacting the university administration directly through o cial channels.

One critical habit I will personally change is implementing a "pause and verify" approach before responding to any urgent digital request. I will enable two-factor authentication across all my accounts, use strong unique passwords managed through a password manager, regularly review privacy settings on social media platforms, and always verify payment requests through o cial channels. Additionally, I've saved the National Cyber Crime Helpline (1930) and will report suspicious activities immediately rather than ignoring them, contributing to broader cybersecurity awareness in my community.

Conclusion

This Digital Literacy Project has been a transformative learning experience that extended far beyond mere technical skill development. Through hands-on tasks spanning design, professional networking, coding practice, communication etiquette, and cybersecurity, I gained practical competencies essential for thriving in today's digital ecosystem. The project taught me that digital literacy encompasses critical thinking, responsible online behavior, and strategic platform utilization—not just technical pro ciency.

Creating my GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle pro les established the foundation for my professional digital presence, while exploring HackerRank and Google Workspace equipped me with tools for continuous learning and collaboration. Mastering email etiquette and understanding cybercrime prevention will protect both my personal security and professional reputation throughout my academic and career journey.

Most importantly, this project instilled a mindset of responsible digital citizenship and lifelong learning. As technology evolves rapidly, the ability to adapt, verify information critically, and use digital tools ethically will remain invaluable. The skills and awareness gained through this project will serve me throughout my four years at VIT Bhopal and beyond, supporting my aspirations in Computer Science, AI/ML development, and professional growth in the technology sector.
